

free the former Greek city-states that had been reconquered by the Persian Empire. After securing the Macedonian throne by destroying his rivals, Alexander set about pursuing his father's quest, while satisfying his own thirst for glory.

King of the world

After forcing the other Greek city-states to accept his authority, in 334 BCE Alexander marched into Asia Minor (modern-day Turkey) at the head of an army of 43,000 foot soldiers and 5,500 cavalry. At its heart lay the Macedonian phalanx, a well-drilled, tight-knit corps of 15,000 men armed with the *sarissa*, a pike that was up to 23 ft (7 m) long. When combined with the shocking cavalry charge provided by the king's personal bodyguard, the Companions, the formation proved irresistible.

After an initial victory over the Persians at the Granicus River in the northwest, Alexander pressed on across Asia Minor. He stopped at Gordium in the central kingdom of Phrygia, where tradition held that he who could untie a complex knot made by the city's founder, would conquer the entire continent. Alexander, in a typically forthright move, cut the knot with his sword. He went on to twice defeat the far superior forces

gathered by Darius III, the Persian emperor—at Issus (on the southern coast of Asia Minor) in 333 BCE and Gaugamela (in modern Iraq) in 331 BCE, subduing Egypt in the interval.

Having forced the Persians into submission, Alexander drove his troops eastward, across mountains, deserts, and rivers into Afghanistan and Central Asia, and on to the Indian Punjab, ruthlessly crushing all resistance. He would have pushed further into India, but in 325 BCE his exhausted men refused to go on.

The Hellenistic legacy

Alexander was now the king of a vast and ethnically diverse empire that included 70 newly founded cities, united by a common Greek culture, customs, and language, and linked by trade routes; although the process of Hellenization was already underway in the western half of Persia before his expedition, Alexander had accelerated its spread throughout the Middle East.

In 323 BCE, Alexander died—most likely from disease but perhaps by poisoning—without naming a successor. His empire was carved up by his leading generals, but some of the Hellenistic dynasties they founded, notably Seleucid Syria and Babylon and Ptolemaic Egypt, survived until Roman times. ■

Alexander the Great



Throughout antiquity, Alexander was widely regarded as the most remarkable man who ever lived, and in terms of the breadth and duration of his renown, which saw

him become a key figure in national literature from Central Asia to Western Europe, he is one of the most famous men in history.

Born in 356 BCE, to parents who claimed descent from demigods and heroes, Alexander's education under the philosopher Aristotle ensured he was steeped in Greek legend, and he came to believe he was invincible, even divine. As a general he was decisive, bold to the point of recklessness—with his own life and those of his men—and a brilliant

tactician. He maintained the loyalty of his forces throughout his long and arduous campaign, but his quick and violent temper, fueled by his heavy drinking, occasionally spurred him to eliminate those closest to him, including his friends. Alexander died at age 32, at the height of his power. His funeral cortège was hijacked by Ptolemy, one of his generals, and diverted to Alexandria in Egypt, where his tomb was later visited by Julius Caesar, but is now lost.